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What It Takes

I found the trio back in the cage where the saga began, and they gathered near the center when they saw me coming.

Once I got inside, I could see something new in their eyes.

"What?"

"Nothing," Liv said. "We're just ready to get to work."

I scanned the three faces, and immediately changed my plan. I had been thinking a little discussion might be warranted. Something to sort of put a bow on things. But, looking at them now, I decided that could wait. Whatever Emma had said had them energized and eager, and all eyes were on me. They were ready for action, so that's what we'd do.

"Alright," I began, "the way I see it, we'll start again from scratch. I know a lot of it will be stuff you've already done, but all three of you still have basic flaws in your technique. We're going to get rid of that."

Three nods. No argument.

No doubt about it. Emma was getting a raise.

I walked over to the training materials I'd prepared earlier and retrieved a pair of focus mitts.

"We'll start with striking," I said.

I stood at the center of the cage and arranged the three around me in a triangle.

"I'll square up with you and call out a combo for you to throw," I said. "Be ready. I'm going to start out going in a circle, but, once we get the hang of it, I'm going to change things up. I may stay square and call a second combo. I may turn back and go the other way."

More nods all around.

"Also be careful. All three of you are still having a problem staying in your stance, and that has to stop. If I see you go unbalanced, I will try to knock you over."

My tone was matter-of-fact. Should they be past this point by now? Definitely. But they weren't. I knew it, they knew it, and the only way to fix it was to wipe the slate clean.

We were only in the second turn when Dove rose out of her stance on the cross. I slipped outside the punch, then planted the mitts against her side and shoved her away.

She stumbled a few steps, then turned and glared at me.

I shrugged and spread my mitts in front of me. There was no enmity in the gesture. She made a mistake, and I took advantage of it. She didn't like it, which told me she would try harder to keep it from happening again. Sounds like learning to me.

For the next few hours, everything around us disappeared. We stayed with the mitts for a long while, and it was funny to witness the bell curve of their progress. What started out sloppy slowly turned more and more solid until they hit the wall and fatigue turned it all back to slop. I glanced at the clock. Over thirty minutes of straight striking drills. Their technique needed work, but I had to admit I was impressed by their conditioning.

After a short rest, I turned them loose on the heavy bags. This allowed me to go from one to the other and give my undivided attention to each. Again, I found myself spending a lot of time on the topic of keeping their balance centered. It seemed minor and more than a little boring, but I kept harping on it because it was essential.

"You can't win if you can't stay centered," I told them. "You can't defend yourself if you're off balance, you can't throw combos if you let your positioning get out of shape, and you can't generate any power if your feet aren't on the canvas."

I stopped well short of saying *hasn't Steph already said this to you a hundred times?* because that would violate the clean slate strategy.

After the bags, we made a half-hearted attempt at grappling techniques, but it quickly became clear that they were beat. They had been pouring everything they had into whatever I asked them to do. On top of that... so much had happened that it was easy to forget I had knocked all three of them flat not that long ago.

When you added it all up, it was safe to say they'd put in a hard day's work.

I called an end to things, and we grabbed our water bottles and sprawled out on the mat.

I felt the need to say something, but gave myself time to think it through. Questions like *where has this been all this time?* and *what the fuck did Emma say to you?* sprang to mind, but I brushed them aside. The past was gone, and the only thing that mattered now was tomorrow.

But first, I had to make something abundantly clear.

"Emma told you guys a story today," I said. "One that was deeply personal to her."

They all gave little nods.

"I don't know exactly what she said, and I don't care. That was between the four of you. But I think she also made it clear that we watch out for our own here. So, while I'm hopeful all three of you will have long and happy careers with us, understand that you better never breathe a word of what she said to anyone outside this organization. Even if you decide this isn't the place for you, that secret stays here. We clear?"

More nodding. More emphatic, this time.

"OK, then... here's the deal," I said. "It's going to be the four of us for the next few weeks. I think we can cover a lot of ground in that time, but how much we get done is up to you."

I paused to observe them again, and I liked the reaction I saw.

"If you guys come ready to play each day, I'll be ready to teach," I continued. "That's what it comes down to."

I saw agreement in their eyes, and I felt something release deep in my chest. Like a weight had been lifted.

Big raise for Emma. Big, big raise.

Then Daya asked a question that turned the conversation in a way I hadn't expected.

"What happens after?" she asked. "You still gonna be around?"

Her comrades seemed eager to hear the answer, as well.

"You guys liked the way things went today?" I asked with a grin I couldn't suppress.

"Was alright," she admitted. "You know... second half, maybe."

My grin broadened as my head started to nod.

"Guess somebody should have hit you guys sooner, eh?"

None of them seemed to find that funny.

"Maybe so," Liv said quietly.

"Remember what I said. We're starting from scratch. Forget what happened before. We go from here."

We shared a long look, then she gave a soft little nod. Like she liked the idea, but couldn't quite let go of the wasted time.

"You never answered my question," Daya observed.

"I think it will be good for you to work with the others when it's possible," I said. "They have a lot of experience, and plenty to teach you. But I can stay as involved as you need me to."

They seemed to like that answer.

"Maybe things didn't start out the way any of us wanted," I continued, "but now we have a chance to do better. What happened before was not just your fault. We had big ideas when we brought you guys on. This grand theory

that the three of you could do more together than you could alone. I still believe that, but I don't think we thought things all the way through. Because the thing is, you guys HAVE gelled. You've got this tight little group thing going on, and that's good. You're there for each other, and that's what we wanted. But you also kind of shut yourselves off from the rest of us."

"We know," Liv said.

"And we're sorry," Dove added.

I shook my head.

"Nothing to be sorry for," I said. "Like I said, it's not all your fault. But now that we see things a little clearer, we have a chance to do better. Step one is for you to loosen up and realize who your friends are."

I spread my arms out wide in a gesture meant to encompass our surroundings.

"We're all on the same team here," I said. "I know some of your teammates intimidate you a little, but you need to get past that. They are your secret weapon. They may give you a hard time sometimes, but they want you to win the same as I do. That's how we work around here."

They were nodding now. Getting into it.

"Something else to keep in mind," I said. "I know you don't like being called kids, but I'm afraid that isn't going to stop. You are kids, and there's nothing you can do about it. But you can change the way it sounds."

I focused on Dove.

"Take it from *those kids can't fight their way out of a wet paper bag* to *Hey, those kids really know their shit*."

She smiled, and I turned my eyes to Z.

"*Those kids look good out there*."

Another smile and I moved on to Liv.

"*Keep an eye on those kids. They're gonna make some noise in this league*."

I earned my third smile, and decided it was time to shut up. It was a good time to end a good day.

"Go hit the showers," I said to them. "We'll pick it up here tomorrow."

They started toward the exit, but Olivia halted them at the cage door.

"What you did earlier," she began. "There were three of us and one of you. How did you do that?"

A big grin spread across my face.

"You want to know?" I asked. "Show me you've got what it takes, and maybe I'll think about it, rookie."

The three mirrored my grin, then continued on their way.

As I watched them go, I couldn't help but notice that there seemed to be a little more bounce in their step. It's funny how a little change in perspective can take a hopeless situation and give it some promise.

My journey out of the training area took me back through the team group, and guess what? Once again, two of RSI's finest were squaring off in an intense sparring session. And, once again, one of them was Danneel Harris.

Her opponent this time was Emily, and boy did Danni have her hands full.

I watched as Em absorbed a combination on her guard, then press forward like lightning as Danni tried to recover. Jab, cross. Danni got her guard back in time, but she couldn't get her feet set before Emily's right foot flashed off the canvas. There was an audible thump when it struck Danni's side, and I joined the others in a chorus of 'Oooohs.'

But Danni didn't get where she is by being lucky. Winning at the top of this sport means you have to take a pounding sometimes, and Ms. Harris knew how to do it right.

If you have to take a shot, make sure you give a better one in return.

Wincing with the impact, Danni fought through the pain and unloaded a right hook from hell. Emily saw it coming, but was out of position to do anything about it. The punch hit her dead in the center of her face. It was a testament to her toughness that it didn't put her out, but it did knock her clean off her feet.

Danni immediately grabbed the binding strap on her right glove with her teeth and ripped it loose. She shook the glove off, then used her newly freed hand to get the other one off as well. As quickly as she'd moved, she was still the third to reach Emily, with Tiz and Steph having gotten there first.

After a few minutes of hushed conversation, I called out to them.

"Everybody alright?"

No sooner did I speak when Emily sat up. Danni looked my way and gave a curt nod. Like she believed Em would be fine now, but hadn't been so sure a moment ago.

The quiet conversation continued, and I couldn't pick up any of it until I heard Emily ask, "How the hell did you do that?"

Danni, feeling better now that Em was up and talking, just smiled and shook her head.

"Don't smile at me," Emily said - though she was smiling now, too. "Do you know how many people I've kicked like that? None of them have ever belted me back before."

Danni added a shrug to the smile, but said nothing.

I knew one thing for certain. The next time Em threw the kick, she'd be more alert to what might come after.

In the meantime, I was becoming aware of something, myself. Emma. Aly. Emily. Danni'd had quite a day for herself, and I suspected that - much to my aggravation - it was going to end earlier than usual.

Less than an hour later, my suspicion was confirmed when she came into my office in her street clothes.

"How's Em?" I asked as she entered my office shortly after the last of the others left for the night.

"She's alright. Trish checked her out. Nothing worse than a bruised ego."

"Compliments of you," I smiled.

She shrugged.

"She said 'no holding back.' That's what I gave her."

"What you gave Emma and Aly, too."

Another shrug.

"They asked for it."

"What was this? *Take a Run at Danni Day?*"

She stretched her neck and rolled her shoulders, trying to loosen the muscles.

"Sure seemed like it to me."

Then came the moment I'd been expecting.

"Speaking of which... I don't think I can go, tonight."

"Aww, you big baby," I teased. "They work you a little harder than usual, and now you need a nap?"

"Kiss my ass," she shot back. "You give those three a try, then tell me how YOU feel."

"Meh," I said. "I still think you're a baby, but we can skip a night, if you need it."

"Aww, thanks for understanding," came her sarcastic response. "And since you're in such a caring mood, there's something else you can do for me."

Danni had spent much of her day doing battle with three of the toughest fighters RSI had to offer. Among other things, that's some serious cardio. So I suspected the request was going to involve the intake of much needed calories.

"You wanna eat," I guessed.

"Oh my god, I'm starving!"

She said it so fast that it all came out as one word, which made me laugh pretty hard.

"Well, then let's get you fed."

"Good," she said as we both stood, "and while we're doing that, you can tell me what the hell happened with the rookies."

"Ah, it was nothing big. We were just stupid, that's all."

She shook her head.

"Why is it always we when we're stupid?"

"You're right," I said. "What was I thinking? I should just put the blame on you."